

01-black-history-month-reading

Black History Month: Texas Trailblazers Reading Passages & Activities

Visual Design Notes

- **Color Palette:** Rich gold, deep burgundy, forest green, cream/parchment backgrounds
 - **Style:** Vintage Texas meets modern — parchment-textured passage backgrounds with bold, colorful headers
 - **Layout:** Each passage on its own styled page with a silhouette portrait frame, Texas star accents
 - **Fonts:** Clean serif for passages (Georgia-style), bold sans-serif for headers (Montserrat-style)
 - **Borders:** Decorative borders with Texas bluebonnets and stars in gold/green
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Passage 1: Barbara Jordan — The Voice of Texas

Reading Passage (Grade 3-5, Lexile 780-850)

Have you ever heard a voice so powerful that it made an entire room go silent? That was the voice of Barbara Charline Jordan.

Barbara was born on February 21, 1936, in Houston, Texas. She grew up in the Fifth Ward, one of Houston's oldest Black neighborhoods. Her family didn't have much money, but they had something even more valuable — a deep belief in education and hard work.

As a young girl, Barbara discovered she had a gift. When she spoke, people listened. She joined her high school debate team at Phillis Wheatley High School and quickly became

one of the best speakers in the state. Barbara won debate competitions against students from all over Texas — even schools that had more resources and funding.

After high school, Barbara attended Texas Southern University, where she continued to sharpen her speaking skills. She then went to Boston University Law School and became a lawyer. But Barbara had bigger dreams. She wanted to change the laws that treated Black people unfairly.

In 1966, Barbara Jordan made history. She became the first Black woman ever elected to the Texas Senate. At the time, many people in government didn't think a Black woman belonged there. Barbara proved them wrong — not with anger, but with intelligence, preparation, and that incredible voice.

But Barbara wasn't finished making history. In 1972, she was elected to the United States Congress, becoming one of the first Black women from the South to serve there. She worked on laws to protect the rights of all Americans, especially those who had been left out.

One of her most famous moments came in 1974 during the Watergate hearings. The whole nation watched on television as Barbara spoke about the Constitution. Her words were so moving and so clear that people across America — no matter their race or political party — were deeply impressed.

Barbara Jordan once said, "What the people want is very simple. They want an America as good as its promise." She spent her entire life trying to make that happen.

Barbara passed away in 1996, but her legacy lives on. The Barbara Jordan Terminal at Austin-Bergstrom International Airport is named in her honor. She showed the world that a girl from Houston's Fifth Ward could change the course of American history.

Comprehension Questions

Multiple Choice (STAAR-style):

1. What is the MAIN idea of this passage?
 - A. Barbara Jordan was a good public speaker
 - B. Barbara Jordan overcame obstacles to become a powerful leader who fought for equal rights

- C. Barbara Jordan grew up in Houston, Texas
- D. Barbara Jordan served in the United States Congress
2. Based on the passage, what can the reader INFER about Barbara Jordan's childhood?
- A. She had an easy life with many advantages
- B. She didn't enjoy school very much
- C. Her family valued education even though they had limited financial resources
- D. She always knew she would become a politician
3. The author uses the phrase "not with anger, but with intelligence, preparation, and that incredible voice" to show that Barbara —
- A. never got upset about anything
- B. used her skills and character to earn respect
- C. was the smartest person in the Senate
- D. had a very loud speaking voice
4. Which detail from the passage BEST supports the idea that Barbara Jordan's impact was felt beyond Texas?
- A. She won debate competitions in high school
- B. She attended Boston University Law School
- C. The whole nation watched her speak during the Watergate hearings
- D. She grew up in Houston's Fifth Ward

Short Answer: 5. How did Barbara Jordan's early life experiences prepare her for her career in politics? Use TWO details from the passage to support your answer.

Writing Prompt

Opinion Writing: Barbara Jordan once said, "What the people want is very simple. They want an America as good as its promise." What do you think this quote means? Do you agree? Write an opinion paragraph explaining your thinking and use details from the passage to support your ideas.

Vocabulary

- **legacy** (noun) — something handed down from the past; the lasting impact of a person's life

- **Reconstruction** (noun) — the period after the Civil War when the U.S. rebuilt the South
 - **Congress** (noun) — the group of elected leaders who make laws for the United States
 - **Constitution** (noun) — the written plan for the U.S. government and its laws
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Passage 2: Bessie Coleman — Queen Bess of the Skies

Reading Passage (Grade 3-5, Lexile 760-830)

Imagine looking up at the sky and dreaming of flying — but being told you could never do it because of the color of your skin. That’s exactly what happened to Bessie Coleman, and it only made her more determined.

Bessie was born on January 26, 1892, in Atlanta, Texas — a small town in the northeast corner of the Lone Star State. She was the tenth of thirteen children. Her family were sharecroppers, which meant they farmed someone else’s land and gave most of what they grew to the landowner. Life was hard, but Bessie was tough.

As a child, Bessie walked four miles to her one-room schoolhouse every day. She loved reading and was especially good at math. She dreamed of doing something important with her life — something no one expected from a young Black girl in rural Texas.

When Bessie grew up, she moved to Chicago to live with her brothers. There, she heard stories from soldiers returning from World War I about flying airplanes. Bessie was fascinated. She decided right then that she would become a pilot.

But there was a problem. No flight school in America would accept a Black woman. Not a single one. Most people would have given up, but Bessie had another idea. She learned French and applied to flight schools in France, where the rules were different.

In 1921, Bessie Coleman earned her international pilot’s license from the Fédération Aéronautique Internationale in France. She became the first Black woman — and the first Native American woman (her mother was part Cherokee) — to earn a pilot’s license anywhere in the world.

Bessie returned to America as a celebrity. Newspapers called her “Queen Bess” and “Brave Bessie.” She performed daring tricks at air shows, doing loops, dives, and figure-eights that thrilled huge crowds. But Bessie had a rule: she refused to perform at any event that segregated Black and white audience members. If everyone couldn’t enter through the same gate, she wouldn’t fly.

Bessie dreamed of opening a flight school for Black Americans, but tragically, she died in a plane accident in 1926 at just 34 years old. She never got to open her school, but she inspired generations of Black pilots who came after her.

Today, every year on the anniversary of her death, Black pilots fly over Bessie’s grave in Lincoln Cemetery in Chicago and drop flowers from their planes. The little girl from Atlanta, Texas changed aviation history forever.

Comprehension Questions

Multiple Choice (STAAR-style):

1. Why did Bessie Coleman go to France to learn to fly?
 - A. She wanted to travel the world
 - B. French planes were better than American planes
 - C. No flight school in America would accept a Black woman
 - D. Her family lived in France
2. The word “determined” in paragraph 1 means —
 - A. angry and frustrated
 - B. firmly decided and unwilling to give up
 - C. confused about what to do
 - D. happy and excited
3. Which sentence from the passage shows that Bessie Coleman stood up for equality?
 - A. “She performed daring tricks at air shows”
 - B. “She loved reading and was especially good at math”
 - C. “She refused to perform at any event that segregated Black and white audience members”
 - D. “Newspapers called her ‘Queen Bess’”

4. What is the MOST LIKELY reason the author included the detail about pilots dropping flowers on Bessie's grave?
- A. To show that Bessie loved flowers
 - B. To prove that Bessie was famous
 - C. To show that Bessie's impact and legacy continue to be honored today
 - D. To explain how pilots fly their planes

Short Answer: 5. What challenges did Bessie Coleman face, and how did she overcome them? Use at least TWO details from the passage.

Writing Prompt

Narrative Writing: Imagine you are Bessie Coleman on the day she earned her pilot's license in France. Write a journal entry describing how you feel, what you see, and what you dream about for the future.

Vocabulary

- **sharecroppers** (noun) — farmers who work someone else's land and share the crops as payment
- **aviation** (noun) — the flying or operating of aircraft
- **segregated** (adjective) — separated by race
- **fascinated** (adjective) — extremely interested in something

Passage 3: Dr. Heman Marion Sweatt — The Man Who Opened the Door

Reading Passage (Grade 3-5, Lexile 770-840)

Sometimes, changing history starts with doing something that seems simple — like applying to school. That's how Heman Marion Sweatt changed Texas forever.

Heman was born in 1912 in Houston, Texas. He grew up in a family that believed deeply in education. His father was a school principal, and education was treated as the most important thing in the Sweatt household.

After graduating from Wiley College, a historically Black college in Marshall, Texas, Heman worked as a mail carrier. But he had a bigger dream: he wanted to become a lawyer. In 1946, he applied to the University of Texas School of Law in Austin.

There was just one problem. The University of Texas did not allow Black students. Texas, like many southern states, had laws that kept Black people and white people in separate schools. This was called segregation, and it was legal at the time.

When the university rejected Heman because of his race, he didn't walk away quietly. With the help of the NAACP (National Association for the Advancement of Colored People), Heman sued the state of Texas. His case, called *Sweatt v. Painter*, went all the way to the United States Supreme Court — the highest court in the country.

Texas tried to solve the problem by quickly creating a separate law school just for Black students. But the new school was tiny and had almost no books, no real campus, and very few professors. It was nowhere close to equal to the University of Texas.

In 1950, the Supreme Court made its decision. The justices ruled that the separate law school was NOT equal, and that Heman Sweatt had the right to attend the University of Texas School of Law. It was a groundbreaking victory.

Heman's case was one of the most important steps toward ending segregation in American education. Just four years later, the Supreme Court used similar reasoning in the famous *Brown v. Board of Education* case, which ended school segregation across the entire country.

Heman Marion Sweatt faced threats and harassment when he enrolled at UT Law. The pressure eventually affected his health, and he left the law school. But his courage opened the door for thousands of Black students who came after him. Today, a directory at the UT School of Law bears his name, and he is remembered as one of the most important civil rights heroes in Texas history.

Comprehension Questions

Multiple Choice:

1. What is the CENTRAL idea of this passage?
A. The University of Texas had a good law school

- B. Heman Sweatt's fight to attend UT Law helped end segregation in education
- C. The Supreme Court makes decisions about schools
- D. Heman Sweatt worked as a mail carrier
2. Why did the Supreme Court rule in Heman Sweatt's favor?
- A. Because Heman was smarter than other applicants
- B. Because the separate law school for Black students was not truly equal
- C. Because Heman's father was a principal
- D. Because the NAACP paid for the lawsuit
3. The word "groundbreaking" in paragraph 7 means —
- A. related to construction
- B. damaging to the ground
- C. new and important; changing the way things are done
- D. happening underground
4. How does the author ORGANIZE this passage?
- A. By comparing two different law schools
- B. By describing events in chronological (time) order
- C. By listing problems and solutions
- D. By giving different people's opinions

Short Answer: 5. Explain how Heman Sweatt's case helped lead to bigger changes in American education. Use details from the passage.

Writing Prompt

Informational Writing: Write an informational paragraph explaining what segregation was and how people like Heman Sweatt helped to end it. Use facts from the passage and anything else you know.

Vocabulary

- **segregation** (noun) — the practice of separating people based on their race
- **sued** (verb) — took legal action against someone in court
- **Supreme Court** (noun) — the highest court in the United States
- **harassment** (noun) — unwanted, aggressive behavior toward someone

Passage 4: Congresswoman Eddie Bernice Johnson — Science, Service, and Texas

Reading Passage (Grade 3-5, Lexile 780-850)

What if someone told you that a nurse from Waco, Texas would one day lead the most powerful science committee in the United States government? That’s the true story of Eddie Bernice Johnson.

Eddie Bernice Johnson was born on December 3, 1935, in Waco, Texas. Growing up in segregated Texas, she learned early that opportunities for Black women were limited — but that didn’t stop her from dreaming big.

Eddie Bernice became a registered nurse and earned her nursing diploma from Holy Cross Central School of Nursing. She later earned a bachelor’s degree from Texas Christian University and a master’s degree in public administration from Southern Methodist University. Education was her pathway to creating change.

In 1972, Eddie Bernice Johnson was elected to the Texas House of Representatives, becoming the first Black woman from Dallas to serve in the Texas legislature. She immediately got to work, focusing on healthcare and helping people in her community get access to doctors and hospitals.

But Eddie Bernice didn’t stop there. In 1992, she was elected to the United States Congress, representing Dallas, Texas. She would go on to serve for 30 years — one of the longest-serving members of Congress from Texas.

What made Eddie Bernice Johnson truly special was her love of science. In 2021, she became the chairwoman of the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology — the first Black person and the first woman to ever lead this powerful committee. She helped make decisions about NASA, space exploration, and scientific research for the entire country.

From her position, she fought to make sure more women and minorities had opportunities in STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math). She believed every

child deserved the chance to become a scientist, engineer, or astronaut — no matter their background.

Eddie Bernice Johnson also helped bring the Inland Port and major economic development to southern Dallas, creating thousands of jobs for people in her community.

When she retired from Congress in 2023, she left behind a legacy of service, science, and breaking barriers. The girl from Waco proved that with education and determination, you can change the world — one law at a time.

Comprehension Questions

Multiple Choice:

1. What makes Eddie Bernice Johnson's role on the Science Committee historically significant?
 - A. She was the youngest person on the committee
 - B. She was the first Black person and first woman to lead it
 - C. She was the only person from Texas on the committee
 - D. She was a scientist before joining Congress
2. Based on the passage, Eddie Bernice Johnson can BEST be described as —
 - A. someone who was only interested in science
 - B. a dedicated leader who worked to create opportunities for others
 - C. a person who preferred nursing over politics
 - D. someone who only helped people in Dallas
3. Which detail from the passage BEST supports the idea that education was important to Eddie Bernice Johnson?
 - A. She served in Congress for 30 years
 - B. She earned multiple degrees from different universities
 - C. She was born in Waco, Texas
 - D. She helped bring jobs to southern Dallas
4. What is the author's PURPOSE in writing this passage?
 - A. To explain how Congress works
 - B. To convince readers to become nurses
 - C. To inform readers about an important Texas leader and her contributions

D. To compare different members of Congress

Short Answer: 5. How did Eddie Bernice Johnson use her position in government to help others? Give TWO specific examples from the passage.

Writing Prompt

Opinion Writing: Eddie Bernice Johnson believed every child deserves the chance to become a scientist or engineer. Do you agree? Why or why not? Write an opinion paragraph with at least two reasons to support your thinking.

Vocabulary

- **legislature** (noun) — the group of people in government who make laws
- **chairwoman** (noun) — a woman who leads a committee or organization
- **STEM** (abbreviation) — Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math
- **legacy** (noun) — something left behind that has a lasting impact

Passage 5: Matthew Gaines — From Slavery to the Texas Senate

Reading Passage (Grade 3-5, Lexile 750-820)

Can you imagine being born into slavery, teaching yourself to read in secret, and then becoming a leader who helped write laws for an entire state? That's the remarkable story of Matthew Gaines.

Matthew Gaines was born into slavery in 1840 in Alexandria, Louisiana. As an enslaved person, he was not allowed to go to school. In most southern states, it was actually against the law to teach enslaved people to read or write. Slaveholders were afraid that education would make enslaved people want freedom even more.

But Matthew was not going to let anyone control his mind. In secret, he taught himself to read. He studied the Bible and became a powerful preacher. His words inspired the people around him, and he became a leader in his community even before he was free.

After the Civil War ended in 1865, Matthew Gaines was finally free. He settled in Washington County, Texas, near the town of Brenham. During this time, called Reconstruction, the United States was rebuilding, and for the first time, Black men were allowed to vote and hold public office.

In 1869, Matthew Gaines was elected to the Texas State Senate. He was one of only two Black senators in Texas at the time. Despite facing racism and opposition from many white lawmakers, Matthew fought hard for the things he believed in.

His biggest accomplishment was fighting for public education. Matthew Gaines helped create Texas's first public school system. He believed that education should be available to ALL children — Black and white, rich and poor. Before his work, many children in Texas had no school to attend at all.

Matthew also fought against a system called “convict leasing,” where prisoners (who were often Black men arrested on minor charges) were forced to work for free, almost like slavery all over again. He spoke out against this injustice when few others would.

Unfortunately, Matthew Gaines's time in the Senate was cut short. His political opponents worked to remove him from office, and Reconstruction-era progress for Black Texans was rolled back. Many of the rights Black people had gained were taken away through new laws and intimidation.

Matthew Gaines died in 1900, and for many years, his story was nearly forgotten. But in 2021, a statue of Matthew Gaines was unveiled on the campus of Texas A&M University in College Station, near where he once lived and served. His story is now being told again — a story of courage, education, and the belief that all people deserve equal rights.

Comprehension Questions

Multiple Choice:

1. What is the MAIN idea of this passage?
 - A. Matthew Gaines was a preacher in Texas
 - B. Matthew Gaines overcame slavery to become a senator who fought for education and justice
 - C. Reconstruction was an important time in American history

- D. Texas A&M University has a statue of Matthew Gaines
2. Why did slaveholders make it illegal to teach enslaved people to read?
- A. They thought reading was too difficult
 - B. They didn't have enough books
 - C. They feared education would increase the desire for freedom
 - D. They wanted enslaved people to focus on farming
3. The word "opposition" in paragraph 5 means —
- A. friendship and support
 - B. resistance or disagreement
 - C. a type of political party
 - D. working together
4. Why does the author include the detail about the statue at Texas A&M?
- A. To show that Texas A&M is a good university
 - B. To explain that Matthew Gaines attended Texas A&M
 - C. To show that his contributions are finally being recognized and honored
 - D. To encourage readers to visit College Station

Short Answer: 5. How did Matthew Gaines's experience as an enslaved person shape his goals as a senator? Use TWO details from the passage.

Writing Prompt

Narrative Writing: Imagine you are a child in Texas in 1870, and you get to attend one of the first public schools created because of Matthew Gaines's work. Write a story about your first day of school. What do you see? How do you feel? What do you learn?

Vocabulary

- **enslaved** (adjective) — forced into slavery; held as property by another person
- **Reconstruction** (noun) — the period (1865-1877) when the U.S. was rebuilding after the Civil War
- **convict leasing** (noun) — a system where prisoners were rented out to work for private companies
- **unveiled** (verb) — shown to the public for the first time

Texas Connection Map Activity

Instructions

Students receive a blank outline map of Texas with major cities marked. For each trailblazer, students: 1. Locate and mark the city connected to the person 2. Write the person's name and one key fact 3. Draw a small symbol representing their achievement 4. Connect the cities with a colored line to show the "trail" of Texas trailblazers

Cities to mark: Houston, Waxahachie/Atlanta TX, Austin, Dallas, Waco, Brenham/College Station

"My Texas Trailblazer" Creative Project

Students choose one of the five trailblazers (or research a new one) and create: - A one-page "biography poster" with an illustrated portrait - 3 key facts about the person - A quote (real or imagined) from the person - Why this person is important to Texas history - A personal connection: "This person inspires me because..."

Google Slides Version Outline

Slide 1: Title Slide

- "Texas Trailblazers: Black History Month Reading & Activities"
- Colorful Texas star background, gold/burgundy/green
- Student name field

Slides 2-6: Reading Passages (one per trailblazer)

- Left side: Reading passage in scrollable text box
- Right side: Illustrated portrait frame with Texas star border
- Background: Parchment texture

Slides 7-11: Comprehension Questions (one set per passage)

- Interactive: Students type answers in text boxes
- Multiple choice formatted as clickable options (students highlight/bold their choice)

Slides 12-16: Writing Prompts (one per passage)

- Lined writing area
- Prompt displayed at top with decorative border
- Word bank sidebar for ELL students

Slide 17: Texas Map Activity

- Interactive map with movable text boxes and pins
- Students drag names to correct locations

Slide 18: “My Texas Trailblazer” Project Template

- Structured template with text boxes for each section
- Image placeholder for student illustration (they can draw and insert a photo)

Slide 19: Vocabulary Review

- Matching activity: drag vocabulary words to definitions